

MAINSTREAM NOTEBOOKS

Mainstream category laptops are budget laptops that offer you mobility and decent performance while working with MS Office, Internet, etc. However, they are no firecrackers when it comes to setting speed records. Though similar to the thin and light notebooks, they differ in the sense that they are heavier, and do not offer great features and a long battery life. These mainstream notebooks weigh around 3 to 3.5 Kgs and are 28 to 30 mm thick. Consider yourself lucky if you get a combo-drive with these models, since CD-ROMs or DVD-ROMs usually accompany them. Similarly, a 20 to 40 GB hard drive is the normal storage capacity. Though 14-

inch TFT LCDs are a standard, certain high-end laptops might offer a 15-inch LCD.

Legacy ports such as parallel and serial may be present. High-end models offer at least two USB ports along with Firewire ports. Most of the mainstream laptops have spruced up configurations, and 256 MB of RAM is a standard fitment. Hence, using Windows XP is not much of a problem. Keep your minimum requirements in mind while buying a mainstream laptop. Pick a model that offers the maximum number of features at a decent price. Do remember to check its weight, as that's what you're going to have to carry.

ACi Ethos4

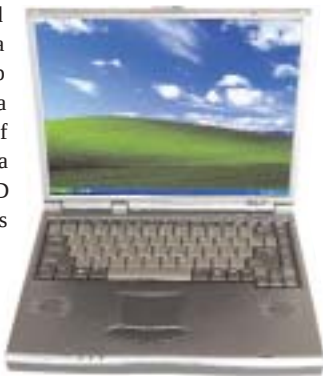
Run of the mill

The ACi Ethos4 is targeted solely at those in need of a decent performing laptop at an affordable price. It has a Pentium4 M 1.8 GHz, 256 MB of DDR RAM, a 40 GB hard drive, a CD-ROM drive, a 14-inch LCD display and a SiS 650 graphics chipset. Also provided are two USB ports, a parallel port and one Firewire port.

Excessive use of dull plastic elements coupled with a dated design gives it a boring character. The keyboard layout is cramped, but the keys provide good tactile feedback. The touchpad is sensitive and accurate, but the entrenched buttons should have been raised a little. The speakers are placed near the palm rest, thus affecting the sound quality. The top lid is locked at both ends, and needs a single slider to open.

Ethos4 had the lowest performance scores in this category. The memory scores were below par, indicating the bottleneck in the memory subsection. The hard disk also returned below average scores. As a result, its overall system performance plummeted—it returned just 19 units in the Business Winstone test. This means that opening multiple Excel sheets, Word documents and Outlook simultaneously will stress the system. Ethos4 logged an average temperature of about 38 degrees, doing better than its other ACi counterpart.

Ethos4 is a good option for those on a shoestring budget. If you can spend Rs 15,000 rupees more, then the nx9005 is a better choice with its elegant business look and decent performance.



Price: Rs 54,990

+ Good hardware configuration for the price

- Dated design

ACi Ethos4	B
Performance	▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮
Features	▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮
Usability	▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮
Value for money	▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮

ACi Optima

Optimum configuration

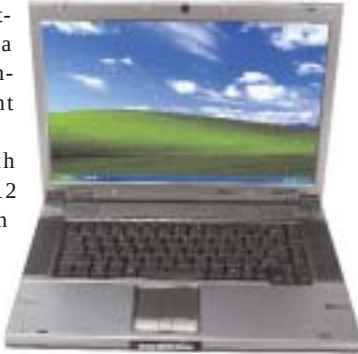
Despite a Centrino platform, the ACi Optima landed with the mainstream laptops due to its weight and dimensions.

The Optima comes with the Pentium M 1.7 GHz, 512 MB of DDR RAM, a 15-inch LCD screen and a 60 GB hard disk. It was the only laptop that had a DVD-RW. It has three USB ports and one Firewire port; wireless capability is offered via an Intel wireless card. All this brings its weight to 3.1 Kgs, and makes it a few centimetres broader than a normal laptop.

The dull silver-grey finish makes it look cheap, and it is not as ergonomic as the Ultima; it lacks finesse and attention to detail. Placed on either side of the keyboard, the speakers sound too tinny. The touchpad is large and comfortable, and the buttons are raised for comfortable use.

The Business Winstone saw it return a terrific 29 units, just 10 less than the Ethos4. The memory scores were third best in the category. We tried in vain to test the hard disk as SiSoft Sandra kept hanging the machine. This is more likely to be a problem specific to the laptop we recieved. The batteries lasted for 3 hours, 16 minutes, which is quite normal for a Centrino laptop. Interestingly, its temperature never exceeded 37 degrees.

The Optima offers the latest hardware at an unbelievable Rs 90,000. Other laptops such as the Wipro Little Genius that are in the same price range, offer good performance but not the same configuration. Opt for it if you want a spruced up Centrino with cutting edge technology.



Price: Rs 89,990

+ Terrific performance, great features

- Low aesthetic appeal

ACi Optima	C
Performance	▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮
Features	▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮
Usability	▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮
Value for money	▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮ ▮